



MILK BEFORE MEAT

Cameron's Field Guide

For your eyes. Every question, every answer, the whole plan in your pocket.

So you never have to scramble for words. Pull this out before
any conversation and you'll know exactly what to say — and
what not to.

START HERE

How to use this guide

This one is just for you. It is the backstage version — blunter, more personal, and more complete than anything you'd hand someone else.

Keep it on your phone. Before you sit down with a friend, a tester, or your bishop, skim the section that fits. Each hard question has a *one-line answer* (the italic line) for when you only have a breath, and a *fuller answer* for when you have a minute.

It also holds the things you told yourself you never want to lose — why you're doing this, the order of the plan, and the lines you must never cross. When you get tired or someone rattles you, come back here. It will steady you.

The golden rule of every pitch: **lead with honesty, not polish.** The most disarming thing you can do is name the hard part before they do. It tells people you've already wrestled with it — and that you can be trusted with their “no.”

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The pitch, three lengths

The ten-second version

“It’s an app that meets people right where they are spiritually — starts with a story, listens, and walks with them — and there’s always a real person one tap away. It’s built to do what Jesus did, just at the scale a phone allows.”

The one-minute version

“You know how missionaries can only be in so many places, and most people scroll past anything that feels like a sales pitch? This app opens with a short, true story about Jesus — no branding, no survey — and then asks one honest question about *them*. It quietly learns where a person is: hurting, doubting, curious, or already a believer, and gives them exactly the next thing that helps. It never pressures. It never pretends to be human. And the second someone wants a real person, they get one. For members, it becomes a quiet place to deepen their own walk with Christ instead of doom-scrolling. It’s milk before meat — the way the Savior taught.”

The five-minute version

Walk them through the screens (use the walkthrough document or your phone): the opening sanctuary, the story, the one question, the way the app reflects their answer back so they feel *seen*, the feed that adapts, the chat that answers gently and always offers a real person, the journal, and the Profile where they can see — and delete — everything the app has learned. Then show the members’ “Walk with Christ” space. End on the honesty: “It’s not endorsed by the Church — it’s mine, and I’m testing it carefully and taking it to my leaders. I’d love your honest read.”

Whatever length you use, end the same way every time: **ask for their honest opinion, and ask them to test it.** You are not selling. You are gathering witnesses.

“Is this even allowed?”

This is the first question almost everyone asks. Lean into it — you have a strong, honest answer, and a whole separate document that backs it with the Church’s own words.

Q Is this app approved or endorsed by the Church?

No — and I never claim it is.

It’s an independent, third-party app that I built and run with volunteers. I’m holding it to the Church’s published AI principles, testing it carefully, and taking it to my leaders. If the day comes that the Church wants a role, that’s their call to make, not mine to assume.

Q Hasn’t the Church been cautious about AI?

Yes — and that caution is exactly the standard I built to.

In March 2024 the Church gave four guiding principles for AI: support don’t supplant the connection to God, be transparent that it’s AI, safeguard sacred and personal information, and stay accountable by reviewing outputs. In December 2025 it added Handbook section 38.8.47 saying AI can’t replace revelation or real relationships. The app was shaped to fit every one of those. I have it all written down with sources in the ‘Within the Lord’s Boundaries’ document.

Q Didn’t Elder Gong warn about exactly this kind of thing?

He drew the map I’m following.

Elder Gong said AI “can answer questions, but it cannot answer prayers,” and that we should let it “deepen, not diminish” our relationship with God — and if anyone’s tempted to confide in a chatbot instead of a real person, reach out to someone who loves them. That’s why a real human is always one tap away in my app, and why the AI never pretends to be the source of truth. It points people *toward* God and real people, not away from them.

Q So why does the app talk about faith at all, if the Church mostly uses AI for logistics?

It’s a knowledgeable friend, not an oracle.

That’s the honest edge, and I name it. The app does go further than the Church’s internal use — it talks about God and doubt. But it never claims to be revelation, never writes anyone’s prayers or talks, and always walks toward scripture the person already trusts and toward a real human. That’s exactly why it stays third-party and volunteer-run until leaders weigh in.

“Isn’t AI dangerous, fake, or cold?”

Q What if the AI says something doctrinally wrong?

It’s built to admit uncertainty and hand off — and I review it.

The AI is taught to stay on the things it actually knows, to say “I’m not sure” when it isn’t, and to offer a real person. In this first phase I can review responses. The whole tester program exists to catch anything off before more people see it — which is the Church’s own standard: regularly test and review outputs.

Q Isn’t it cold or fake to talk to a machine about God?

It’s a doorway to real people, not a replacement for them.

The app never pretends to be a person, and it doesn’t want to be the destination. It’s the warm front porch — it listens, it’s patient, it’s never too busy — and then it opens the door to a real human, real scripture, and eventually real missionaries. A lot of people will say something to a patient screen that they’d never say to a stranger first.

Q Could it manipulate vulnerable people?

It’s designed to do the opposite — it honors a “no.”

No pressure, no shame, no guilt tactics. Spiritual safety matters more than any conversion number. The app will let someone walk away completely, just like Jesus let the rich young ruler walk away. If anything, it errs toward gentleness.

Q What about people in real crisis — mental health, self-harm?

It listens for that and points to real help and real people.

The app is built to notice distress language and respond with care, not doctrine — and to put a real human in front of them. It is not a therapist and never pretends to be.

“Isn’t it sneaky to hide that it’s LDS?”

This is the objection that stings, because it sounds like it’s about honesty. Here is how you answer it without getting defensive.

Q Why doesn’t it say up front that it’s a Latter-day Saint app?

Same reason Jesus opened with a story, not a survey.

There’s a difference between hiding what you are and not leading with everything at once. The Savior taught in parables, gave milk before meat, and met people where they were — the woman at the well didn’t get the whole theology in sentence one. The app is plain that it’s an AI companion and that a real person is there. It just doesn’t dump ‘convert to my church’ on someone who’s hurting — it earns the right to that conversation, and it never lies about what it is when they’re ready to know.

Q But isn’t the Church’s rule that people must know it’s AI?

Yes — and they do.

The transparency principle is about people knowing when they’re talking to AI, and on that the app is completely open. *When* to introduce the restored gospel is a missionary-method question, not an AI-honesty question. Two different things, and the app is honest on both.

Q What happens when someone realizes it’s leading toward the Church?

By then it’s a conversation between friends, not a bait-and-switch.

The app only opens the deeper, restored-gospel content once a person has shown they’re open to it — that they believe God is good and are curious about Him still speaking. It’s a response to *their* readiness, never a trick. And they can always say no and still keep everything good they found.

“What about my data and privacy?”

Q Where does my information go?

It mostly stays on your own phone.

The app is local-first — your journey lives on your device. On the Profile screen you can see *everything* the app has kept about you, and remove any line with one tap; removing it means the app stops using it. You’re never a hidden data point.

Q But the AI replies come from a big tech company’s model, right?

Yes, and I’m honest about that.

When there’s internet, replies are generated by a commercial AI model. The Church’s Handbook warns members against putting sensitive *Church* records into outside AI tools — this app isn’t handling Church records at all, and the most personal material stays on the device. As it grows I’ll put formal data commitments in writing. I name this openly in the boundaries document.

Q Who is the “real person” I’d be connected to?

Right now, me — later, trained volunteers, and one day maybe missionaries.

In this first phase, connection requests come to me and I review the AI’s answers. Phase two adds a small team of trained volunteers. Phase three is the dream: real missionaries integrated in, if the Church ever wants that. It’s built so those later phases slot in without a rewrite.

Answers by audience

A skeptical member

LEAD WITH

The honesty and the guardrails. “A real person is always one tap away. It never pretends to be revelation. I’m testing it and taking it to my bishop.”

DON'T

Oversell or act like it’s finished. Their doubt is a gift — it’s the exact feedback you want.

Your bishop / a priesthood leader

LEAD WITH

Submission and accountability. “I want your honest read, and I want to do this under counsel. Here’s how it lines up with the Church’s AI principles, and here’s where it pushes a boundary — I’m not hiding that.” Hand them the boundaries document.

DON'T

Ask them to endorse it or imply the Church is behind it. Ask only for honest feedback and for help finding more testers.

Non-LDS family / friends

LEAD WITH

The human part. “It’s a gentle app that starts with a story and listens — no pressure, and a real person if you want one. Would you try it and tell me what you honestly feel?” Use the simple brochure.

DON'T

Open with doctrine or “join my church.” Let the app be what it is — milk first.

A tech-worried parent

LEAD WITH

Control and safety. “You can see and delete everything it knows. It won’t shame anyone, it points to real people, and it watches for someone in real distress.”

DON'T

Get pulled into a debate about AI in general. Bring it back to *this* app’s specific guardrails.

Why you're doing this

Keep this where you can find it on the hard days. It's the "why" in your own words, so you never lose the thread.

The restored gospel is **defensible** — beautifully, patiently defensible — and modern tools and research make that more true, not less. Seekers are out there right now with no one tuned to meet them where they are. You don't want to leave them without something built carefully and prayerfully to do what the Savior did: notice the one, tell the story, ask the honest question, and wait.

You believe this should exist. You also believe it has to be done *right* — humbly, under counsel, inside the Church's boundaries, and always pointing back to real people and the Church itself. That tension isn't a problem to solve. It's the whole discipline of the work.

"And whoso receiveth you, there I will be also, for I will go before your face. I will be on your right hand and on your left."

DOCTRINE & COVENANTS 84:88

When you doubt whether you're the one to build this: you're not asked to be perfect, only faithful and careful. Test it, take it to your leaders, listen hard, and let God carry the part you can't.

The plan, in order

Don't skip steps. The order is the integrity of the thing.

- **Step 1 — Get many members testing it.** Friends first, then their friends. You're gathering honest opinions on whether it's good yet, and witnesses who've seen it.
- **Step 2 — Bring in your bishop.** Show him openly, hand him the boundaries document, and ask him to help gather more members to test and give honest feedback. Ask for counsel, not endorsement.
- **Step 3 — Document everything against the Church's words.** Keep the boundaries document current. Every time someone raises a concern, write the honest answer down.
- **Step 4 — Make the proper call to the Church's Intellectual Property office** before ever using the Church's name, logo, or materials. Until then, stay clearly independent.
- **Step 5 — Grow only as fast as it's good.** Phase 2 adds trained volunteers to answer real-person threads. Phase 3 is the long-term hope of real missionaries, if the Church ever wants it. Build for it; don't presume it.

If anyone pushes you to skip ahead — to launch big, to slap the Church's logo on it, to claim approval — that's the moment to slow down. The patience is the witness.

Lines you never cross

- Never claim the app is endorsed, sponsored, or owned by the Church — until and unless it is.
- Never use the Church’s name, logo, or materials before clearing it with the IP office.
- Never let the AI generate images of Heavenly Father or Jesus Christ, or imitate a leader’s voice.
- Never let the AI pose as revelation or write someone’s prayers, blessings, talks, or lessons.
- Never bury or remove the “real person” path. It is always one tap away.
- Never pressure, shame, or guilt anyone. Honor every “no” completely.
- Never hide what the app is when a person is ready to know.
- Never treat a number as more important than the person it represents.

“I have fed you with milk, and not with meat: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it.”

1 CORINTHIANS 3:2

The one-card cheat sheet

If you only remember five things

- It does what Jesus did: story first, listen, meet them where they are, never pressure.
- A real person is always one tap away. The AI never pretends to be one.
- It's mine, not the Church's — I'm testing it and taking it to my leaders.
- It honors the Church's AI principles, and I'm honest about where it pushes a boundary.
- I'm not selling. I'm asking for an honest test and honest feedback.

The line that ends every pitch

“Would you try it, and tell me honestly — is it good yet? Where does it fall short? I’d rather hear the hard thing now than later.”

When someone raises the hard one (“is this allowed / is it sneaky?”)

Don't flinch. “Good question — here's the honest answer,” then give the one-liner from chapters two and four. Offer the boundaries document. Your calm honesty is the proof.

Private working document for Cameron. Not for distribution. Independent of, and not an official publication of, The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.